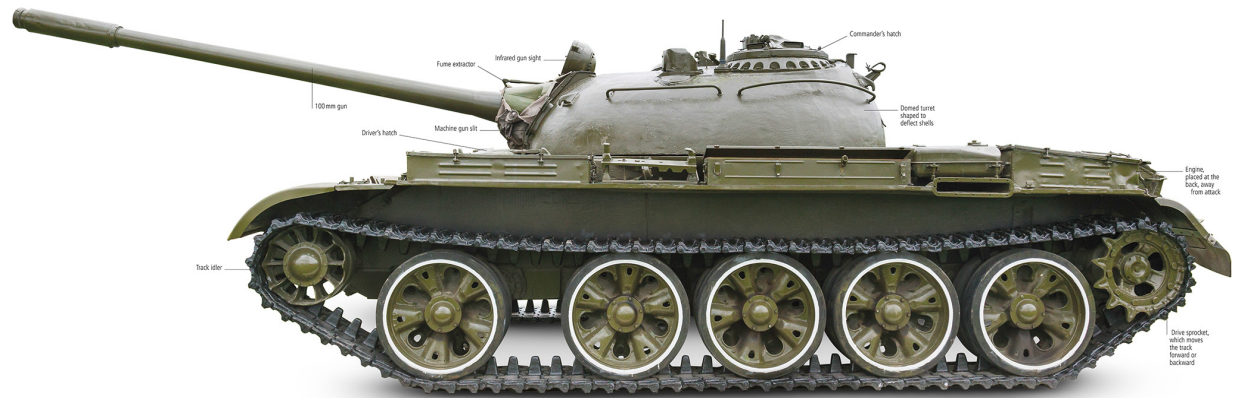


attack began. Hanoi expected to overrun those provinces, as well as Kontum and Pleiku in the Central Highlands. In the Saigon region, the 301 Group was to take the capital. The final pieces in the plan were for the Viet Cong to attack in the Mekong Delta and for more NVA troops to enter northern Laos.

The NVA committed almost all its forces, keeping only one division in reserve. Evoking a heroic figure in Vietnamese history, Hanoi called the campaign the Nguyen Hue Offensive, after the warrior (also known as Quang Trung) who defeated a Chinese invasion in 1789 and went on to become a modernizing emperor of Vietnam.



The T-54 Tank

Communist allies augmented the NVA's supply of light PT-76 tanks with medium T-54 or T-55 vehicles, which were a better match for the US M48. Crewed by four, the T-54 had a top speed of 34 mph (55 km/h).

“[We] **must annihilate** as much ... of the
US and [its] puppet's potential as
possible.”

TRUONG CHINH, SPEECH TO THE VIETNAM FATHERLAND FRONT, PUBLISHED FEBRUARY 3,
1972